Baby Talk

By Doug Wright

INTRODUCTION

I'd like to bring your attention to Case Number 696724-B A woman-approximately twenty-two years old, one hundred and five pounds, with no previous history of mental disturbance. Admitted for auditory hallucinations and social affective disorder. We'll call the subject "Alice." Alice became symptomatic at the time of her first – and only – pregnancy. Baby Talk by Doug Wright

ALICE: We had a big calendar up in the kitchen with big yellow boxes, rimmed with Highlighter. Those were ovulation days! He even came home over his lunch hour . . . . Then one day – finally – the stick turned blue. Sky blue . . . . I remember.

PSYCHIATRIST: Needless to say, however, Alice was . . . surprised . . . when the baby began to – to – vocalize – while still in the womb.

ALICE: I knew I'd feel things. Flutters. Kicks. But sounds? Soothing. Like those tapes you buy of rainstorms, or the lapping of waves.

PSYCHIATRIST: Soon, however, the sounds hardened into syllables.

BABY: Bah. Fah. Pah. Hom. Ling

PSYCHIATRIST: In my encounters with Alice, I tried to suggest – delicately, of course – that the sounds were organic in nature. Gastrointestinal.

ALICE: His first word in-utero. I'll never forget it:

BABY: Conundrum

ALICE: An ambitious word. More sophisticated than one would expect. I'd lie on my back, and drape my hands over my belly. I'd hear them in my sleep.

BABY: Free-fall. Sartorial. Quaff.

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ALICE: When I woke up, I'd write them down. Half the time, I had to consult a dictionary. "Quaff?"

BABY: "To drink deeply. To drain. To take long draughts."

ALICE: My vocabulary grew by leaps and bounds.

PSYCHIATRIST: By its fifth month, the child was composing sentences.

ALICE: With most babies, it's "Gimme wa-wa" or "Baby hafta poo."

PSYCHIATRIST: But instead, the child opted for a loftier tone.

BABY: (In a thrilling baritone) "When the wintry branches scrape the sky, on midnight steed Death gallops by!"

ALICE: Again! Oh, say it again!

BABY: "Happy families are all alike, but every unhappy family is unhappy inits own way."

ALICE: I've never been much of a reader myself. And I certainly don't compose poetry; I couldn't even rhyme "spoon."

BABY: Loon. Moon. June. Festoon. Harpoon. Macaroon. Sasquetoon.

PSYCHIATRIST: Alice began to take dictation from the child.

ALICE: The notebooks. Three of 'em, spiral-bound. One was full of poetry. The second was anagrams –

BABY: Dog. God!

ALICE: That kinda thing. And the last . . . the last was Eastern philosophy, mostly.

BABY: (Intones a sacred Buddhist chant)

ALICE: We'd planned on raising our child Presbyterian; now I wasn't so sure.

PSYCHIATRIST: Soon the child's fascination with language waned; it opted instead for pragmatism.

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BABY: (Rapid-fire, tough) And it's High-Tone on the outside, on the outside, Shenandoah in third place . . . and Musket Fire's pulling ahead . . . pulling ahead . . taking the lead! Musket Fire's in the lead.

ALICE: The ponies; it's true!

PSYCHIATRIST: Alice would drape the racing forms about her mid-section, and in her ear the infant would coo:

BABY: Lucky Lady in the Third Lap . . . Ten down on Strawberry Fields.

(Alice places the bet)

PSYCHIATRIST: Alice, who had never before demonstrated an interest in the track, soon found herself spending long afternoons there.

ALICE: I used my winnings to buy a wicker bassinet and a hand-sewn collection of antique baby quilts. Our child was the beneficiary; not me.

PSYCHIATRIST: In the kitchen, she would open The Joy of Cooking, and slip it under her elastic waistband. While she puttered amidst mixing bowls and measuring cups, the baby would recite the recipe.

BABY: (A French chef's accent) That is the miracle of the phyllo pastry; it is densely layered, but it still has a light texture.

ALICE: Once we made bulgur pilaf. Another time . . . mmmmm! – fennel puree.

BABY: Another dollop of crème de cacao! Why so stingy!

ALICE: It was nice to have someone there with me. To do things.

BABY: (Playing chess) Checkmate

ALICE: Sometimes, he'd let me win. Just to buoy my confidence.

BABY: (Doing a crossword puzzle). Sixteen across: What's an eight letter word that means hyperbole?

ALICE: Some women complain about the third trimester; not me. The days flew.

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BABY: (Playing twister) Right hand, red. Left foot, green. I'm gonna spin it now. I'm gonna spin it . . . . Left hand, yellow. Right foot, blue!

ALICE: Around the 7th month, his tone changed. It . . . ah . . . deepened.

BABY: (Seductively) I like you in the red dress better.

ALICE: Frankly, it was nice to know that he had preferences.

BABY: Why, Alice. You cut your hair.

ALICE: He noticed.

BABY: (Low, sensual) You're wearing them tonight, aren't you? Aren't you? The silk panties with the ecru lace?

PSYCHIATRIST: It wasn't until the 8th month that the fetus became impertinent.

ALICE: I'd jolt awake in the middle of the night. I'd be sweating into my pillow. It would hiss. Hiss at me.

BABY: (Hissing) Water weight, water weight, water weight . . . .

ALICE: Water weight, water weight, water weight . . .

PSYCHIATRIST: By the 9th month, the child had turned insidious.

BABY: Remember those foot braces you wore as a baby? Clunk, clunk, clunk against the sides of your crib . . . (Alice nods with recognition and dread). Well wait'll you see me. I've got webbed toes and a purple rash. (Alice gives a tiny cry of horror). Spina bifida!

ALICE: (Terrified now) Oh, God.

BABY: Hydrocephalus.

ALICE: No!

BABY: Dwarfism!

ALICE: No, no, no – I saw the sonograms, I saw them myself - - -

BABY: DOWN'S SYNDROME!

ALICE: Each little finger, each little toe

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BABY: You'll have to enroll me in . . . sp . . . sp . . . sp . . . SPECIAL classes, and physical therapy, and – once a week or so – *cranial drainage* –

ALICE: I don't have the strength, I don't have the patience . . .

BABY: Pushing me down the aisle of Toys 'R' Us in a motorized stroller with the tubs and the fibrulator – (with Satanic reverb) YOU'RE CONDEMNED TO LOVE ME REGARDLESS – EVEN IF I'VE A FORKED TONGUE AND A TAIL!!!!

ALICE: I was its room, I was its board, I was its future. How could it . . . How dare it . . . I didn't want to birth it; no. I wanted to expel it. I wanted to purge it from my body. But most of all . . . I wanted to confront it, face to face.

PSYCHIATRIST: The day finally arrived. The labor was grueling

BABY: I'M NOT LEAVING! SQUATTER'S RIGHTS! YOU PACK UP YOUR FORCEPS, BONE-MAN, AND YOU GET THE HELL OUTTA MY MAMA'S PRIVATES! I GOT HER BY THE KIDNEY – I GOT HER BY THE BOWELS – AND I AIN'T GONNA LET GO.

ALICE: Then I saw its head crown Seven pounds, six ounces. Twenty-one inches long. Blue eyes, with the palest tufts of blonde hair.

PSYCHIATRIST: The doctors bathed the baby, and soon delivered a small, pink bundle into Alice's arms (Alice raises her arm as if holding the baby.) It lay there, wrinkled, its blurry eyes exhausted from the rigors of birth.

ALICE: (Belligerent) Well? What do you have to say for yourself now? It clammed up. It just lay there.

PSYCHIATRIST: It squirmed and it drooled, but it didn't say a word. It could cry full-throttle and later – after a few months – it would babble, but as for grand pronouncements and poetry readings, well, there were none.

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ALICE: It's a battle of wills, that's all. But one day it will happen. It will crack open its little maw. It'll use its tongue to shape poison arrows. It will begin innocently enough, I'm sure. "Da-da" "Boo-Boo" But the rest will follow soon enough. It might take months. It might take years. But – in the end vengeance will be mine.

BABY: (Giggles)

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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